
Bruno Fernandes breaks club record as Man United close on CL qualification

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Always fun when you get to this stage of a season and just stumble upon a game that so neatly sums up precisely where things are at.

This clash between Manchester United and Aston Villa was billed as [a crucial game in the race for Champions League football](#) next season, but you always sensed which way it was likely to go. [It's pretty clear who carried the momentum into this game between two teams who started the day level on points.](#)

And sure enough, it was Michael Carrick's United who took a huge step towards their target. We can already say with certainty that United will not be getting away with playing only 40 matches next season, and we can now *almost* say that they'll be playing on Tuesdays and Wednesdays for their midweek engagements.

Despite England's last-16 clusterf*ck, [it still seems all-but certain fifth place will be enough](#), and increasingly hard to see how United don't occupy one of the three remaining TBC places in that top five when the music stops. They have an advantage in both points, momentum, form and energy over rivals who have had far busier seasons.

The other three all look various shades of knackered. [Especially Chelsea](#) but *especially* Liverpool but **especially** Villa, who gave it their best here but are looking a little lost. For so long unlikely title contenders, it now looks like they might be relying on tame finishes from others to remain in a Champions League spot. They might still get that help, but it won't come from United.

Then there was the manner of the United goals, which were enormously on brand. The first two were scored from Bruno Fernandes assists, taking his season tally in the Premier League to a club-record 16 and twice as many as his nearest challenger from all-comers this season (Rayan Cherki, stat fans).

The first was a corner headed home by Casemiro, the second a delicious through ball expertly finished by Matheus Cunha.

He could have had a third as well with a carbon copy of the second assist to send Benjamin Sesko through, only for the Slovenian to shank his shot inexplicably wide. But by that point Sesko had already done the necessary from his perspective, with his customary supersub goal having already made the points safe.

Harder to make a Ross Barkley goal in big 2026 fit the predictability narrative, so let's just ignore that for now.

The quality of Casemiro's header for an opening goal that United had been threatening but never truly convincingly since the early stages was a reminder that while his legs are not what they were and replacing what he now offers in the middle of the park shouldn't really be that difficult, his contributions in both penalty areas are not so easily recreated in the round.

You do worry for Villa, though. They've been conspicuously outclassed in recent weeks by both Chelsea and now United. Football is a cruel and mysterious game. Sixth place would have been an

acceptable finish in August, beyond the wildest dreams of early September, but now a crushing disappointment after so long spent breathing the rarefied air with Arsenal and Man City.

They are a world away from the team that put together that 12-wins-in-13 surge at the end of 2025 and have now taken just a single point from their last four games.

It's a fascinating run-in for a Villa side who, even if they drift out of the top five, are going to have a huge bearing on the relegation fight if nothing else. They've got West Ham and Forest either side of the international break, and right now you'd fancy those teams battling for their lives over the team that spent much of the season in the title race. They've got Spurs a few weeks later, but let's not lose the run of ourselves; this struggling version of Villa might not be great, but they're not Spurs either.

They are struggling, though. Ollie Watkins cut a lost and frustrated figure here, with Morgan Rogers also just not at it as he was earlier in the campaign. United's accidental 40-game cheat code does feel like a significant reason for the contrasting energy levels here, and you do wonder whether Villa might be approaching a key decision-making moment.

For Spurs and United last season, it was a straightforward decision from the start of the knockouts to place all eggs in the Europa League basket. Villa aren't there yet, but the day when that route starts to look mighty appealing grows closer by the game.

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